Building in the Age of AI

Prompt pack from the workshop. Zoltán Fodor · zoltanfodor.dev

The idea in one line

AI didn't take the work, it took the waiting. What didn't speed up is your job: taste, knowing the customer, and making the call. **Cut the waiting, keep the craft.**

Start with the task you hate most

Don't start your AI transformation with a strategy deck. Start with the one task you hate most, because you know it inside out (so you can judge the output), it comes back every week (so it pays back), and you feel the relief on day one.

```
I want to hand a task I hate to AI. The task: [describe it in 2–3 sentences].
Interview me with 5 short questions, one at a time, about how I do it today, what
good output looks like, and what must never go wrong.
Then write: 1) the steps as a checklist, 2) the instructions for a Project / Gem that
does it with me, 3) what I still check myself every time.
```

Your first week with AI

Monday	Pick the task you hate most.
Tuesday	Make one Project / Gem with your context: product, customers, glossary, voice, templates.
Wednesday	Connect one tool through MCP (a "connector": Drive, Gmail, Notion, Slack…).
Thursday	Write down what you never cut: customer data, checking, the decision.
Friday	Let it run. After two weeks, keep it or drop it.

Brief it like a smart new hire

The wording matters far less than the context. Every good prompt has five parts:

Role	Context	Task	Format	Check
who should it be?	your docs, customers, rules	one clear job, in steps	table, list, one page	"no data" is an allowed answer; quote sources

Three levels

1 Chat: you ask, it answers. **2 Project:** with your own docs and rules (the biggest single jump). **3 Agent:** it gets a goal, plans, does, checks, and repeats until done. Aim for level 2 this week.

We cut

- ~~the waiting~~
- ~~the perfect first draft~~
- ~~the spec nobody reads~~

We never cut

- ✓ protecting customer data (business account, training off)
- ✓ checking every number, law and quote
- ✓ the decision: that's yours

From idea to launch: the prompts we used

1. Validate with real customer words

```
Role: a senior product researcher.
Context: [your idea in 1–2 sentences].
Task:
1. Search public sources for what real users say about the problem and the existing solutions: app store reviews, G2 / Capterra, Reddit and forums. Leave out people building or selling a tool.
2. Group the complaints into 5–7 themes.
3. For every theme: how many separate posts or reviews mention it (no percentages), 2 short verbatim quotes, each with its link, marked (opened) or (snippet).
4. The 3–5 existing solutions people mention, and what they like and hate about each.
5. Top 3 opportunities (frequency × pain).
Format: one table of themes, then at most 10 bullets.
Check: only use what you actually found. Every quote needs a link. If something cannot be found, write "no data". Do not invent numbers.
```

Then: "*List every quote behind the top theme with its link.*" Open a few yourself.

2. A simple business case

```
Write a simple business case for this idea: the problem and for whom, impact hypotheses, an assumptions table (assumption | pessimistic | base | optimistic | how we would validate it), the result for the 3 scenarios with the calculation shown, risks, what we would measure in a 2-week test, and a verdict: Go, Narrow or Stop. Clearly mark what is an assumption and what is a fact. Do not invent market data; write "to validate" instead.
```

3. Red team your own plan (the most valuable prompt)

```
Review this plan through four pairs of eyes: 1) a skeptical engineer, 2) the customer who says no and would never pay, 3) an investor, 4) a bank's risk and compliance officer (customer data, regulation, fraud). Each writes the 3 biggest gaps or risks. Then update the plan and list what changed.
```

Good design with AI

"Make it modern and clean" gets you the same generic AI look as everyone else. Instead: **real references → your rules → three variants side by side → you pick, it refines → check it on a real phone.**

```
[attach 2–3 screenshots of apps you admire]
Build a clickable mobile prototype (one HTML page) from this spec: the main list
screen with 6–10 realistic made-up records, a detail view, settings if needed, and an
empty state.
Use the screenshots as the visual reference for spacing, type sizes, density and
tone. Do not copy their brand.
Make three variants side by side (A, B, C) that differ in layout, not just colour.
```

Write your taste down once

```
From the chosen variant, write a short design-rules.md: colours (hex), font family
and sizes, spacing scale, corner radius for controls and for cards, what is banned
(for example gradients, heavy shadows), and a rule that every screen has an empty
state. At most 15 lines.
```

Attach that file to every design or code request. If you correct the same thing twice, add it to the file.

When a chat gets long: hand off, start fresh

Long chats get worse: early rules fade, things in the middle get lost. Don't argue for twenty more messages. Ask for a handoff, open a new chat, paste it in.

```
Write a handoff so a fresh chat can continue this work without reading this
conversation. Max 15 lines:
1. Goal, in one sentence.
2. Decisions made so far, and why (one line each).
3. What is done, what is not.
4. Open questions, and who decides them.
5. The exact next step.
6. Files, links or numbers the next chat must have.
Leave out everything we tried and dropped, unless the reason matters.
```

Automate the boring operations

```
Every weekday at 8:00:
1. Read new emails in the support inbox from the last 24 hours.
2. Group them by topic and write a 5-line summary for me.
3. Draft a reply to each one, using the tone and answers in my "support-rules" file.
Do NOT send anything.
4. Create a ticket for every bug report, quoting the customer's words.
5. Put anything urgent at the top.
```

It drafts, you approve. Anything that sends, pays or deletes waits for you.

Where to start

Assistant	ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini
On your own docs	NotebookLM
Prototype	Figma Make, Lovable, Claude
Full project	Lovable, Claude Code
Start a real app from	a template, not a blank page: Vercel templates (AI chatbot, next-forge), v0
Meeting notes	Gemini in Meet, Granola
Agent	Claude Cowork, ChatGPT Work

Know where it stops: AI is faster and better on first drafts, summaries, prototypes and ideas, and confidently wrong on your customers, fresh rules, local law and numbers without a source. Always ask for the source.

Slides, every prompt, skills, guides and 300+ links: **github.com/ritmillio/building-in-the-age-of-ai**